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Term Paper on

Leadership in Practice: A Critical Analysis of Sir Fazle Hasan Abed

Group - 03
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LETTER OF TRANSMITTAL

May 07, 2026

Dr Sheikh Tanzila Deepty
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Honorable Teacher:
Subject: Submission of the Term Paper on Leadership in Practice: A Critical Analysis of Sir Fazle Hasan Abed

With due respect we, the undersigned students of BBA 31st Batch(A), 1st year, 2nd semester have reported on the Leadership in Practice: A Critical Analysis of Sir Fazle Hasan Abed that you authorized on May 07, 2026, under the course F-106 (Principles of Management).This paper provides an in-depth analysis of the leadership style, vision, and contributions of Sir Fazle Hasan Abed, the founder of BRAC. It highlights how his innovative and transformational leadership approach has played a vital role in social development and poverty alleviation, both in Bangladesh and globally.

I, on behalf of our team, would like to express my sincere gratitude for your guidance and support throughout the preparation of this paper. I hope this report finds you satisfactory.

Sincerely,
On behalf of Group-03
Rafia Akter Rafi
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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Sir Fazle Hasan Abed (1936–2019) was one of the most influential development leaders of the 21st century. He founded BRAC (Bangladesh Rural Advancement Committee), now the world's largest non-governmental organization, which has touched the lives of over 100 million people in 11 countries in Asia and Africa. In this paper, we critically analyzed his leadership style, decision-making approach and factors that contributed to BRAC's extraordinary success. Abed was a unique blend of servant leadership, social entrepreneurship and pragmatic business practices, a model that challenges conventional thinking about development work. His transition from Shell Oil corporate executive to social revolutionary shows how personal conviction, strategic vision and unwavering commitment to serving the poor can transform entire communities and create sustainable solutions to poverty. This analysis examines his servant leadership philosophy, his creative use of social enterprises to achieve financial independence, and the key lessons his work provides to future managers and social leaders.

1 | Profile of Sir Fazle Hasan Abed

Early Life and Education

Sir Fazle Hasan Abed was born on April 27, 1936, in Baniachong, a remote village in northeastern Bangladesh (then British India). He came from a distinguished family- his maternal grandfather served as ministers for agriculture and education in Bengal during the final years of British Colonial rule. Despite his priviledged background as a zamindar (Landowner) family member, Abed showed an early inclination toward social consciousness. He completed his secondary education at Pabna Zilla School and intermediate studies at Dhaka College. At age 18, he left home to oursue naval architecture at the University of Glasgow in Scotland, later qualifying as a Cost Management Accountant in London. This technical education provided him with the analytical rigor and financial acumen that would later distinguish his approach to development work- combining the precision of accounting with the compassion of humanitarian concern.

Corporate Career and the Turning Point

In 1962, Abed returned to East Pakistan (as Bangladesh was then known) to work as a senior executive at Pakistan Shell, eventually becoming Haed of Finance. Bt all conventional measures, he was successful- financially seccure, well-positioned in corporate Bangladesh's elite, and living a comfortable executive lifestle. However, two cataclysmic events fundamentally altered the trajectory of his life. The first was tge devastating cyclone of 1970, which killed approximately 300,000 people in coastal Bangladesh. Witnessing this carastrophe and the inadequate response, Abed realized that his corporate comforts and high salary seemed "inconsequential and meanigless" in the face of such human suffering . This realization motivated him to establish HELP (a relief organization) with friends to provide rehabilitation to survivors on the island of Manpura, which had lost three quarters of its population. The second transformative event was the 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War. Abed left his job and moved to London, where he co-founded Action Bangladesh to lobby European governments for his complete transition from corporate executive to social activist- a shift driven by conviction rather than circumstances.

Founding of BRAC

When Bangladesh gained independence in December 1971, Abed returned to a devasted nation. Ten milliion refugees who had taken shelter in India during the war were returning home, and the country's infrastructure lay in ruins. With meager personal savings from selling his London flat, Abed established Brac in 1972 in the remote region of Sulla in northeastern Bangladesh. What began as a modestrelief and rehabilitation project for returning refugees would envolve into a transformative force in global development. Rather than viewing poverty alleviation as charity, Abed approached it as a system problem requiring rigorous research, strategic planning, and sustainable solutions. From dat one, he embedded a Research and Evaluation Department in BRAC- a radical move that seperated it from typical relief organizations. This commitment to evidence-based practice and continuous learning became a hallmark of BRAC's operations and a key factor on its success.

2 | Overview of Brac

Scale and Global Reach

Under Abed's leadership, BRAC grew from a small relief project into the world's largest non-governmental organization. By 2019, BRAC operated in 11 countries across Asia and Africa, with a staff of over 100,000 and an annual budget exceeding $1 billion. The organization has directly touched the lives of more than 100 million people, with programs reaching across all 64 districts of Bangladesh. BRAC's reach extends to education (with over 7 million students enrolled in its schools), health, microfinance, agriculture, human rights, environmental protection, and social enterprises. Remarkably, BRAC has achieved and maintained its position as the top-ranked NGO globally by NGO Advisor for multiple consecutive years, based on impact, innovation, and sustainability- a testament to Abed's vision of building a sustainable, measurable, and scalable development organization.

Organizational Structure and Diversification

What distinguishes BRAC from traditional NGOs is its holistic ecosystem approach. Rather than remaining a single-purpose organization, BRAC intentionally diversified into interconnected programs and social enterprises. The organization comprises development programs, microfinance operations, social enterprises including BRAC Bank, BRAC University, and various for-profit ventures, and mission-aligned investments. This unique structure reflects Abed's conviction that poverty alleviation requires multi-dimensional, integrated solutions. Programs in microfinance are paired with business training; education initiatives are linked with livelihood development; health services connect to nutrition and sanitation programs. This integration of development and business approaches became Abed's signature strategy for sustainable impact.

3 | Leadership Style Analysis

Servant Leadership

Sir Fazle Hasan Abed exemplified servant leadership- a model in which the leader's primary motivation is to serve others rather than exercise power or accumulate personal benefits. Unlike transactional leaders who use incentives and rewards to motivate employees, or charismatic leaders who inspire through personal magnetism, Abed inspired BRAC staff through shared mission and collective purpose. He believed that meaningful work serving the poor was intrinsically motivating. According to BRAC's institutional memory, Abed fostered a culture where staff felt genuine **"pride and ownership"** in their work, viewing themselves as part of a historic movement for social change. He called BRAC staff "Abed Bhai" (brother) - a term of familial respect- emphasizing that leadership was not hierarchical command but collaborative service. His humility was legendary, despite founding one of the world's largest organizations, he maintained close connections with field staff and remained open to challenges to his ideas. This servant leadership approach proved remarkably effective in sustaining institutional commitment and institutional memory even as BRAC grew to massive scale.

Visionary Pragmatism

Abed's leadership style combined visionary idealism with ruthless pragmatism. His famous maxim- "Small is beautiful, scale is necessary"- captures this tension. He believed in the beauty and potential of small communities and local solutions, yet he insisted that truly addressing poverty required scaling interventions to reach millions. This philosophy prevented BRAC from becoming either a small, boutique development organization or a massive bureaucracy divorced from ground realities. Abed used evidence-based analysis to ground his vision in reality. He invested heavily in research and evaluation not as an afterthought but as a core organizational function. When BRAC decided to enter microfinance, he didn't import models wholesale from other countries; instead, his team rigorously studied what worked for poor Bangladeshi women. This generated insights that became influential globally. His pragmatism manifested in a willingness to use business mechanisms to achieve social goals; a controversial position for traditional NGOs at the time. Abed didn't view making profit as contradictory to social mission; rather, he saw it as the means to achieve financial independence and sustainability.

Ethical Leadership and Moral Conviction

Abed's leadership was fundamentally rooted in ethical principles. He refused to compromise BRAC's independence or mission, even when faced with political pressure. In one notable instance, politicians approached him asking him to use BRAC's influence to affect voting behavior of his employees. Abed refused categorically, stating that BRAC was apolitical and existed to serve the poor, not political interests. This commitment to ethical boundaries helped BRAC maintain credibility and independence throughout decades of political instability in Bangladesh. His famous quote- "I have met many defeated men in my life. I have never met a defeated woman" which reflects his core conviction that human dignity, potential, and agency are universal and not determined by circumstance. This ethical

conviction shaped all of BRAC's work, particularly its focus on empowering women as agents of social change rather than passive beneficiaries of development.

Communication Style

Abed communicated through both formal and informal channels. He regularly wrote thought pieces and gave interviews explaining BRAC's vision and approach. His communication was marked by clarity, intellectual humility and strategic framing. Rather than relying on inspirational rhetoric, he communicated through stories, evidence, and logic. He was known for listening deeply to field staff and incorporating their insights into organizational strategy. This communication style created genuine engagement rather than mere compliance, allowing BRAC to function as a learning organization even as it scaled. His repeated phrases like "Small is beautiful, scale is necessary" and emphasis on "blending business acumen with development practice" became part of BRAC's organizational language, shaping how staff understood their roles and decisions.

4 Key Factors Behind Success

Vision and Strategic Thinking

Abed possessed a comprehensive vision of poverty alleviation that went far beyond conventional charity. Rather than treating poverty as a single problem with a single solution, he understood it as a complex phenomenon requiring multi-dimensional interventions. His vision encompassed education, health, microfinance, agriculture, skills development, and gender empowerment- all integrated into a coherent system. Crucially, this vision was grounded in research. BRAC's Research and Evaluation Department didn't merely measure outcomes; it generated strategic insights about the underlying causes of poverty in different contexts. This research orientation allowed BRAC to continually refine and adapt its approach, pioneering innovations like the Graduation approach for ultra-poor households- an evidence-based model that has now become influential globally and influenced government policies in multiple countries.

Innovation and Risk-Taking

Abed was a strategic risk-taker willing to venture into uncharted territory. When BRAC decided to enter microfinance in the 1980s, this was considered risky for an NGO- the assumption was that poor women couldn't reliably repay loans. BRAC's microfinance program not only proved this assumption wrong but became one of the world's largest microfinance operations, eventually growing into BRAC Bank, which now serves hundreds of thousands of clients. Similarly, Abed's decision to establish social enterprises including Aarong (a fair-trade craft enterprise), BRAC Bank, and BRAC University was innovative for its time. These weren't peripheral activities but core to his strategy for achieving financial independence from donor funding. By generating revenue from social enterprises and program-related investments, BRAC reduced dependency on donor whims and gained autonomy in strategic decision-making. This approach proved prescient; many NGOs became vulnerable in later years when donor funding dried up, but BRAC's diversified revenue streams provided resilience. Abed's willingness to fail and learn from failure was also critical. Not all BRAC initiatives succeeded; some were discontinued after rigorous evaluation showed insufficient impact. This commitment to evidence over sentiment distinguished BRAC from organizations that became attached to pet projects regardless of effectiveness.

Employee Management and Organizational Culture

Abed understood that BRAC's success ultimately depended on the motivation and capability of its staff. He created an organizational culture where employees felt they were part of a historic mission. Staff were recruited not primarily for technical skills but for commitment to the mission with technical training provided on the job. BRAC offered modest salaries compared to corporate positions, yet

attracted and retained talented people because the work was meaningful. Abed fostered an environment of intellectual engagement where staff were expected to think critically, question approaches, and contribute ideas. The organization invested heavily in staff development and learning. Despite BRAC's size, Abed maintained accessibility to leadership, creating psychological safety for dissenting views. This institutional culture proved crucial for sustaining quality as BRAC expanded internationally. The organization faced challenges when operating in new countries, but its strong organizational culture and commitment to learning allowed it to adapt while maintaining core principles

Ethical Standards and Integrity

In the context of Bangladesh, where corruption was endemic, Abed's unwavering commitment to organizational integrity was remarkable and consequential. BRAC developed robust systems for financial accountability and transparency which were essential for maintaining donor confidence and staff motivation. Abed refused to engage in political patronage or compromise organizational principles for short-term gains. This integrity built BRAC's reputation, making it a trusted partner for governments, international organizations, and donors. More profoundly, the ethical culture permeated all levels of the organization. Staff understood that cutting corners or compromising quality was not acceptable, regardless of external pressure. This commitment to quality and integrity became embedded in BRAC's brand, helping it attract resources and partnerships.

Financial Discipline

Abed's background as a management accountant directly shaped his approach to financial management. BRAC maintained rigorous financial controls, transparent accounting, and rigorous cost-effectiveness analysis of all programs. Every major initiative was subjected to financial scrutiny: What was the cost per beneficiary? How could the same impact be achieved at lower cost? Could the program eventually become self-financing? This financial discipline prevented the bloat and inefficiency that sometimes affects large development organizations. It also enabled BRAC to optimize resource allocation, directing funds to activities with the highest impact. Abed's insistence on cost-effectiveness didn't mean cutting corners on quality; rather, it meant identifying the most efficient way to deliver quality. This balance of excellence with efficiency became BRAC's operational hallmark and a key reason for its impact per dollar spent.

5 | Social Entrepreneurship and Innovation

The Social Enterprise Model

Abed's approach to social enterprise was both pragmatic and visionary. He recognized that traditional NGO models, dependent on donor funding, face chronic sustainability challenges. Donor priorities shift, funding becomes unpredictable, and organizations lose strategic autonomy. Abed's solution was to embed for-profit social enterprises within BRAC's ecosystem. These enterprises are commercially viable, generating profits while advancing social mission. Unlike traditional corporate social responsibility initiatives, BRAC's enterprises aren't philanthropy; they're legitimate businesses designed to scale impact and achieve financial independence. The classic example is Aarong, BRAC's fair-trade craft enterprise. Aarong employs thousands of artisans (predominantly women) in rural Bangladesh, providing fair prices, market access, and holistic support services. Through Aarong's retail outlets and e-commerce, customers in developed countries purchase authentic Bangladeshi crafts while supporting rural livelihoods. Aarong is profitable, reinvesting surpluses into community programs. This model has inspired similar initiatives globally and demonstrates how business can be a vehicle for social change.

Microfinance Innovation

BRAC's entry into microfinance in the mid-1980s was transformative. At the time, mainstream development thinking questioned whether poor women could reliably repay loans. BRAC's rigorous research and careful program design proved this assumption wrong. BRAC's microfinance program focused specifically on women in poverty, providing not just loans but complementary services: business training, group formation, literacy classes, and health education. This holistic approach achieved repayment rates exceeding 98%, comparable to commercial banks. The program scaled dramatically, reaching millions of borrowers across Bangladesh and internationally. Recognizing the potential for financial self-sufficiency, BRAC eventually established BRAC Bank in 2001, a regulated financial institution offering banking services at commercial rates. BRAC Bank became profitable, paying dividends while reaching underserved populations. This transition from donor-dependent program to self-sustaining financial institution exemplifies Abed's vision of achieving development impact through business mechanisms.

Other Social Enterprises

Beyond Aarong and BRAC Bank, Abed expanded social enterprises into diverse sectors. BRAC University provides quality higher education to talented poor students, combining affordability with academic excellence. BRAC Food and Agriculture Enterprise works to improve agricultural productivity among small farmers through improved seed varieties and farming techniques. BRAC Health ventures provide essential healthcare services in underserved areas at affordable prices. These

enterprises aren't sideline activities; they're central to BRAC's integrated approach to development. Each enterprise generates revenue that supports BRAC's broader mission while directly addressing community needs. This diversification also provides resilience: if one enterprise faces challenges, others provide stability. The model demonstrates that nonprofit organizations can think and act like businesses without compromising social mission.

6 | Challenges and Criticisms

Organizational Autonomy vs. Dependency

While BRAC's social enterprises achieved significant scale, they didn't entirely eliminate donor dependency for the NGO's core development programs. Education programs in ultra-poor areas, for instance, operate at a loss; they're subsidized by commercial enterprises and donor funds. This raises legitimate questions: Has BRAC genuinely achieved financial independence? Could the current scale of impact be maintained if donor funding evaporated? Abed was transparent about these constraints, understanding that certain types of development work (serving the ultra-poor in remote areas) may never be fully self-financing. However, critics argue that the emphasis on social enterprise occasionally diverted resources from the poorest populations, who cannot generate immediate commercial returns.

Mission Drift

A continuing challenge for large development organizations is mission drift, the gradual shift away from core goals toward activities that are easier to finance or quantify. As BRAC expanded into sectors such as banking, retail, higher education, and international operations, some critics questioned whether it was still centered on serving the poorest communities. With increasing commercialization, concerns arose about whether BRAC could preserve its poverty-focused mission. Abed responded by putting strong institutional safeguards in place. Every program and enterprise was carefully assessed in line with BRAC’s objective of poverty alleviation. Initiatives that did not contribute to empowering marginalized groups or reducing poverty were closely examined. Even so, for an organization as large and diverse as BRAC, maintaining clarity of purpose and consistency across different sectors and regions remains an ongoing challenge.

International Expansion Challenges

BRAC's expansion beyond Bangladesh in 2002 brought new challenges. Operating in different countries with distinct legal, cultural, and institutional contexts required significant adaptation. Early international programs faced implementation challenges, with some initiatives requiring course corrections. The question of whether BRAC's Bangladesh-tested models could be successfully transplanted to other contexts proved more complex than anticipated. This highlighted that Abed's leadership, while creating strong institutional culture, was also intensely personalized. Questions about succession and institutional continuity loomed as Abed aged. How would BRAC maintain its mission and culture without its founder's active guidance? This concern became acute following Abed's death in December 2019, leaving BRAC to navigate institutional transformation.

Limited Political Advocacy

Some development advocates criticized BRAC for not engaging enough in political advocacy or pursuing broader systemic change. Although the organization was highly effective in delivering services and implementing programs at the community level, it remained cautious about directly challenging government policies or participating in political activism. This approach reflected BRAC's strategy of maintaining independence from politics. However, critics argued that long term solutions to poverty require structural change, including reforming unjust laws, addressing corruption, and ensuring government accountability. Abed believed that BRAC's main role was to demonstrate practical solutions by developing successful models that governments could later adopt. He viewed large scale political change as uncertain and potentially risky compared to proving that alternative approaches could work in practice. Whether this position represents strategic wisdom or a limitation continues to be debated among development scholars.

7 | Managerial Lessons

Why Did Abed Succeed?

Sir Fazle Hasan Abed succeeded where many development leaders did not because of a distinctive combination of qualities. First, he held a deep conviction in the potential of poor communities and an unwavering commitment to serving them; this was not a career move but a defining life choice. Second, he balanced idealism with pragmatism, pairing a strong vision for social transformation with careful reliance on evidence and practical action. Third, he understood that lasting impact depends on building strong institutions, not simply delivering services, and he invested in organizational capacity, staff development, and systems even when these efforts were not immediately visible to donors. Fourth, he recognized that financial sustainability is essential for independence and introduced innovative social enterprise approaches to achieve it. Fifth, he upheld ethical integrity in a context often marked by corruption, establishing an organization widely respected for its honesty and transparency. Sixth, he cultivated a mission driven culture that attracted and retained talented individuals despite limited financial incentives, because the work itself carried purpose and meaning. Finally, he appreciated the importance of evidence and continuous learning, embedding research and evaluation into the core of the organization rather than treating them as secondary concerns. Together, this blend of vision, practicality, institutional strength, financial innovation, ethical leadership, strong culture, and commitment to evidence made his approach exceptionally effective.

Practical Lessons for Future Managers

Several practical lessons emerge from Abed's leadership that apply beyond the development sector:

- Visionary leaders often operate on conviction, but Abed grounded his vision in rigorous research and real world understanding. He emphasized learning before scaling solutions and supported this through strong systems for evaluation and continuous improvement.
- Organizations, whether nonprofit or for profit, need sustainable revenue models. Exploring ways to align mission driven work with income generating activities can ensure financial independence and greater strategic flexibility.
- Organizational culture is a key source of strength and competitive advantage. Promoting clarity of purpose, integrity, and a supportive environment helps retain talented individuals even when financial incentives are limited.
- Leadership should focus on serving the mission and its beneficiaries rather than seeking power or status. Encouraging shared responsibility and inclusive decision making strengthens the organization.
- Ethical standards must be upheld at all times, even under pressure or when short term gains are tempting. Embedding integrity into systems and daily practices ensures it continues over time.
- Growth requires more than simply expanding activities. Strong systems for quality control, knowledge management, and adaptability are essential to maintain effectiveness at scale.

- Staying open to feedback and valuing insights from frontline staff helps build a learning oriented organization. Creating clear channels for communication and acting on feedback leads to better performance.
- It is important to balance growth with focus by maintaining the strengths and quality of smaller operations while achieving broader reach through well designed systems.

Critical Perspectives

While BRAC's achievements are undeniable, critical scholars raise important questions about development approaches and the limitations of NGO led change. Some argue that despite BRAC's impressive scale, structural poverty and inequality in Bangladesh continue to exist, suggesting that even highly effective NGO interventions may struggle to address deeper systemic causes. Others point out that BRAC's success was partly shaped by specific historical conditions, including post independence Bangladesh's openness to foreign organizations and the availability of donor funding after the Liberation War, which may not be easily replicated in other contexts. In addition, the strong focus on BRAC's founder, while understandable, reflects a broader concern in development work about over dependence on charismatic individuals instead of building fully institutionalized organizations. After Abed's passing, BRAC faces the challenge of sustaining its unique culture and commitment without his direct leadership. This represents an important test of whether its values and systems have truly become embedded within the institution or whether they remained closely tied to Abed's personal influence.

8 | Conclusion

Sir Fazle Hasan Abed represents a distinctive model of transformational leadership that combined servant leadership principles with social entrepreneurship, rigorous evidence based management, and a strong ethical commitment. His decision to leave corporate comfort and dedicate his life to serving the poor was driven by personal moral conviction rather than external pressure. His ability to expand that commitment from a small relief initiative into the world's largest NGO reflects strategic insight, organizational understanding, and practical innovation.

BRAC's success cannot be attributed mainly to Abed's personal charisma, although he was a highly effective communicator. Instead, it is largely the result of the institutional systems, organizational culture, and approaches he established. The organization's expansion into social enterprises, integration of development programs, commitment to research and evaluation, and consistent ethical standards all reflect a strategic vision that has become deeply embedded in BRAC's structure and practices.

For future leaders in the nonprofit, public, or private sectors, Abed's example offers important lessons. Purpose driven action supported by evidence can generate meaningful impact. Sustainable business models strengthen independence. Servant leadership and strong organizational culture significantly enhance effectiveness. Ethical commitment, even when difficult in the short term, helps build institutions that endure beyond individual leadership.

As BRAC moves forward without Abed's direct guidance, the key test of his legacy is whether the organization can preserve its distinctive identity and commitment. This will show whether his vision has been fully institutionalized. Early indications suggest that decades of deliberate institution building have created strong resilience and cultural depth capable of supporting leadership transitions. Ultimately, Abed's life demonstrates that leaders guided by conviction, dedication, and strategic thinking can drive large scale transformations that improve millions of lives and inspire future generations of change makers.

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